

*“Above the Earth.”*

On a late Tuesday night, I stepped into my backyard and watched the orange contrail glisten against the dark sky. Having moved to Florida, a mere 100 miles from Cape Canaveral's NASA field center, I have been fortunate enough to experience spacecraft and their development firsthand. Spending the early years of my life in North Carolina left me feeling connected to aircraft. Being a short 200 miles from where the first ever flight took place, I could look in any direction and be reminded of the advancements by the “First in Flight” red text printed upon license plates. This always present cue to the history and the human desire to soar has always felt inspiring. Airplanes, spacecraft, flight: the exploration of the world from miles above. This concept will forever fascinate me. Since humanity first began to understand traversing the land, we have wanted more. We have wanted to explore the sky. For as long as I can remember, I have been immersed in the sky from traditional aviation to astronautics. Experiencing the visitor center for the first time at Kennedy Space Center opened my eyes to the beauty of the final frontier; meanwhile, the captivating nature of the Wright Brothers National Memorial roped me into a lifelong affection for manmade wings.

In my earliest years I can recall the stories my father would tell of how he had long dreamed of attending flight school, getting his pilot's license, and flying commercially. As the years passed, I found myself growing more engaged in the dreams my father had idolized before me, though in a different way. I found myself immersed in its roots. Traveling countless times from either Fort Lauderdale-Hollywood International Airport or Orlando International Airport direct into Raleigh-Durham International Airport only gave more opportunities to fuel my engagement. Though in nearly every circumstance, the memories that lasted had far more to do with the adventure than the destinations.

At this rapidly changing portion of my life, my childhood infatuation with aerospace feels less trivial now. This interest has become deeper. It has become a reminder to never stop moving, to always take risks, and to always push forward in the face of adversity. Any turbulence that I may pass through will be simply that, something to pass through. For every long layover, every unexpected delay, and every rocky landing, my desire to keep going only grows stronger. I will keep flying; I will continue forward to my destination. It is not the arrival that is most exciting but the views from the window along the way. Life is the same in this way; looking forward to the future, to the destination, is not the purpose, but rather the purpose is to enjoy the moment, take in the scene, and be grateful for every experience. Moving forward to this new chapter of my life will be demanding yet so fulfilling. I cannot wait to take off again.